Paisalin Pangandaman Tago

Atty. Paisalin Pangandaman Tago, CPA (born October 25, 1967) is a Filipino lawyer, certified public accountant, and the 9th Regular President of the Mindanao State University (MSU) System, appointed on June 27, 2025, by President Ferdinand R. Marcos Jr.<ref name="appointment">MSU Main Campus, "Mindanao State University Welcomes the 9th Regular President of the System, MP Atty. Paisalin P. Tago," accessed March 10, 2026, https://www.msumain.edu.ph/the-9th-regular-president-of-the-msu-system/</ref> A native of Marawi City and a Maranao by birth and by formation, Tago brings to the MSU presidency more than three decades of government work spanning finance, law, regional legislation, and executive administration. He is widely credited as one of the architects of the fiscal foundation of the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM), most notably for his central role in securing the block grant provision of the Bangsamoro Organic Law and for filing the proposed Bangsamoro Revenue Code. His investiture at MSU on August 13, 2025, introduced a Nine-Point Agenda built around the Latin maxim he has adopted as both personal and institutional standard: *Acta non verba*, or Actions, not words.<ref name="profile">MSU Main Campus, "The System President," accessed March 10, 2026, https://www.msumain.edu.ph/the-system-president/</ref> At its core, Tago's presidency represents an argument that has defined his entire career: that durable peace in the Philippine South depends less on declarations than on institutions that actually work.

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Early Life and Cultural Formation

Paisalin P.D. Tago was born on October 25, 1967, in the Islamic City of Marawi, the provincial capital of Lanao del Sur and the undisputed cultural center of the Maranao people.<ref name="profile"/> Marawi sits on the shores of Lake Lanao, one of the oldest and most biologically significant lakes in Southeast Asia, and the city's social life has historically been organized around the interplay of Islamic scholarship, genealogical rank, and communal obligation. Growing up there is not quite the same as growing up anywhere else in the Philippines, because the standards by which public figures are judged, and the expectations placed on those who carry community trust, are shaped by a tradition that predates the Philippine republic by centuries.

Tago describes himself as a "blue-blooded native" of Marawi, <ref name="profile"/> a phrase that carries real weight in the Maranao context. It is not a claim to aristocratic privilege so much as a statement of accountability. It says, in effect, that he answers to the community that produced him, that his conduct in public life is measured against older and more demanding standards than any administrative code, and that his return to MSU as its president is not simply a career achievement but a kind of homecoming with obligations attached.

Marawi also sits at a geographic crossroads. Historically positioned as a hub for road networks across Central Mindanao, <ref name="wikipedia_msu">Mindanao State University, Wikipedia, accessed March 10, 2026, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mindanao_State_University</ref> it has long been a place where trade, education, and inter-community exchange converge. For Tago, that meant an early, lived education in what regional integration actually looks like at the ground level, long before he encountered the phrase in any policy document.

His wife, Sittie Norhaya Ambor-Tago, is herself a Certified Public Accountant, and the couple are raising four children.<ref name="profile"/> The household mirrors the professional values

Atty. Paisalin P. Tago, CPA



Full Name	Paisalin Pangandaman Tago
Born	October 25, 1967 Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Maranao
Spouse	Sittie Norhaya Ambor-Tago, CPA
Children	4
Education	BSBA, National College of Business and Arts LLB, Far Eastern University MLaw studies, San Beda College
Credentials	CPA, Member of the Philippine Bar
Fellowship	East-West Center, Honolulu (New Generation Seminar)
Current Position	9th Regular President, Mindanao State University System
Appointed	June 27, 2025, by President Ferdinand R. Marcos Jr.
Term	Six years (2025–2031)
Previous Roles	Minister of Transportation and Communications, BARMM Member, Bangsamoro Parliament Speaker/Floor Leader, ARMM Regional Legislative Assembly Commissioner, NCMF

he has carried through every public role: a preference for measurable accountability, an orientation toward precision, and the understanding that the unglamorous work of administration is what makes everything else possible.

	Board Member, Cooperative Development Authority
Governing Maxim	*Acta non verba* (Actions, not words)

Education and Professional Training

Tago holds a Bachelor of Science in Business Administration from the National College of Business and Arts and a Bachelor of Laws from Far Eastern University, where he obtained his legal degree. He pursued graduate legal studies at San Beda College, enrolling in a Master of Laws program.<ref name="bionote">MSU Main Campus, "Atty. Paisalin P.D. Tago, CPA – Bionote," accessed March 10, 2026, https://www.msumain.edu.ph/wp-content/uploads/2025/07/Atty.-Paisalin-P.D.-Tago-CPA-Bionote.pdf</ref> He passed both the CPA board examinations and the Philippine Bar<ref name="profile"/>, placing him among a relatively small group of practitioners who hold professional licensure in both accounting and law. That combination is not incidental to his career. A lawyer who can read a government balance sheet with confidence handles fiscal legislation differently than one who cannot, and an accountant without legal training is limited in what institutional frameworks he can construct. Tago has operated fluently in both registers for most of his professional life.

His academic preparation was rounded out by a fellowship at the East-West Center in Honolulu, Hawaii, where he participated in the New Generation Seminar, a program bringing together emerging leaders from across Asia and the Pacific for structured exchange on governance, development, and cross-cultural policy.<ref name="bionote"/> The East-West Center is a federally chartered institution established by the United States Congress, and its fellowship process is selective. For Tago, the Honolulu experience exposed him to comparative governance models and to peers from countries navigating their own versions of the minority-integration challenges he had grown up watching in Lanao del Sur. The regional and cross-cultural perspective he developed there would later inform his vision of MSU as an institution with academic relationships reaching well beyond the Philippines.

Government Service: From Accounting Offices to the Legislature

Early Government Roles

Tago entered government service not through electoral politics but through the finance offices, the places where the actual condition of public administration shows up in ledger columns, budget variances, and unexplained shortfalls. His earliest posts, as Supervising Accountant in Land Transportation Regional Office 12 and then as Chief Accountant and Budget Officer III in the Office on Muslim Affairs, placed him where national policy met regional reality, often badly.<ref name="bionote"/> What he encountered was a pattern he would spend much of his career trying to correct: fiscal arrangements designed in Manila that did not account for the cost structures, geographic realities, or institutional capacities of Muslim Mindanao. Programs arrived underfunded. Deadlines were written for an administrative calendar that assumed urban infrastructure. Accountability mechanisms presumed a level of institutional depth that many provincial offices did not have.

That early exposure was diagnostic in a way that would matter later. By the time Tago moved into legislative work, he already knew from direct observation what the ARMM's fiscal problems looked like at the transaction level, a quality of knowledge that most legislators arriving from purely legal or political backgrounds do not possess.

The ARMM Regional Legislative Assembly

His entry into the Regional Legislative Assembly (RLA) of the Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao began a twelve-year engagement with regional governance that few officials in the Bangsamoro system can match in breadth.<ref name="bionote"/> He served as Speaker, Majority Floor Leader, and Assistant Minority Leader, positions that placed him at different points along the parliamentary spectrum and required him to understand the logic of governance from more than one institutional vantage point.<ref name="bionote"/> Between 1993 and 1994, he also served concurrently as Finance Director in the Office of the Regional Governor-ARMM,<ref name="bionote"/> bringing him inside the executive branch at a time when the ARMM was still defining what regional autonomy meant in practice. Moving between the legislature and the executive, understanding each from within the other, produced a kind of institutional literacy that is difficult to acquire any other way.

National and Provincial Roles

Outside the ARMM, Tago's service record covered multiple levels of government. As a Board Member of the Cooperative Development Authority from 2011 to 2015, he engaged with community-based economic institutions and the governance frameworks that sustain them.<ref name="bionote"/> As Commissioner of the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos from 2015 to 2018, he worked within the national agency responsible for the welfare of Muslim communities across the country, a post that required navigating between community interests and the priorities of successive national administrations.<ref name="bionote"/> At the local level, his service as a member of the Sangguniang Panlalawigan of Lanao del Sur kept all of this national and regional work grounded in the specific realities of his home province.<ref name="bionote"/>

By 2019, when the Bangsamoro transition formally began, Tago had served in local, provincial, regional, and national capacities, across legislative, executive, and quasi-judicial bodies, in the fields of finance, law, transportation, and community development. It is that accumulated range, rather than any single role, that sets his preparation apart.

Building the Bangsamoro's Financial Architecture

The passage of Republic Act No. 11054, the Bangsamoro Organic Law (BOL), in 2018, and the formal establishment of the BARMM in 2019 created both an historic opportunity and a structural problem. The new autonomous region had political authority on paper. What it lacked was the financial machinery to exercise that authority without remaining practically dependent on whichever national administration happened to be in power. Converting formal political autonomy into functional fiscal self-governance became the central project of Tago's Bangsamoro parliamentary career.

The Block Grant Provision

In the Bangsamoro Parliament, Tago is identified as a principal figure in securing the block grant provision of the BOL, the mechanism by which the BARMM receives an automatic share of national tax revenues, protected by statute and not subject to annual legislative appropriation.<ref name="bionote"/> He also served as consultant to the Senate during the BOL deliberations,<ref name="bionote"/> a role that allowed him to track the provision through the national legislative process and ensure its protective language survived the committee stage. The Intergovernmental Fiscal Policy Board, designed to periodically review the block grant formula, was among the institutional mechanisms whose creation he supported, essentially a built-in correction device for a formula that was always going to need adjustment as the region's economic profile evolved.<ref name="dof">Department of Finance, "National and Bangsamoro Governments approve review of BARMM's share in national tax collections to

promote fiscal autonomy and development," accessed March 10, 2026, https://www.dof.gov.ph/national-and-bangsamoro-governments-approve-review-of-barmms-share-in-the-national-tax-collections-to-promote-fiscal-autonomy-and-development/</ref>

The fiscal scale of what that provision secured is substantial. Between 2020 and 2024, the Bangsamoro Government received PHP 337.53 billion in block grant transfers,<ref name="dof"/> providing the financial continuity that sustained regional operations across the change of national administration in 2022. For a region whose previous autonomous arrangement, the ARMM, had been perpetually underfunded and politically vulnerable, the block grant was a structural shift rather than an accounting change.

The Bangsamoro Revenue Code

As Chairperson of the Committee on Ways and Means, Tago filed Parliament Bill No. 286, the proposed Bangsamoro Revenue Code, a measure to establish a systematic regional framework for taxation, resource rents, and non-tax fees.<ref name="bionote"/> The BARMM, he argued in floor debates, commands roughly 3,000 kilometers of coastline and 18 million hectares of territorial waters,<ref name="revenue_code">Bangsamoro Parliament, "Proposed Bangsamoro Revenue Code seeks to strengthen fiscal autonomy," September 5, 2024, accessed March 10, 2026, https://parliament.bangsamoro.gov.ph/2024/09/05/proposed-bangsamoro-revenue-code-seeks-to-strengthen-fiscal-autonomy/</ref> a resource base whose economic potential had remained largely untapped because no legal mechanism existed for the regional government to derive income from it.

In public debates, Tago was direct in addressing the concern that a regional revenue code would simply mean new burdens on ordinary residents. His argument was that the code was a claim on natural resource wealth and commercial activity that had long generated income for interests outside the region. The revenue it generated, he maintained, would fund infrastructure, health facilities, and educational programs that the block grant alone could not cover.<ref name="revenue_code"/>

Digitalization and Transparent Governance

Tago coupled the Revenue Code with an advocacy for digital tax administration, the argument that electronic revenue collection systems would improve compliance, reduce administrative leakage, and make the BARMM's fiscal management visible to its own citizens in real time.<ref name="digitalization">Bangsamoro Parliament, "BARMM pushes digitalization to promote transparency, increase revenue collection," May 17, 2024, accessed March 10, 2026, https://parliament.bangsamoro.gov.ph/2024/05/17/barmm-pushes-digitalization-to-promote-transparency-increase-revenue-collection/</ref> Legal assessments of the proposed digital framework confirmed its compatibility with both the BOL and the Philippine Constitution.<ref name="digitalization"/> In the BARMM, where institutional infrastructure is still under construction and public trust in government financial systems remains a live question, the push for digital administration carries specific political weight. Throughout his career, Tago has treated transparency not as a supplementary virtue but as a functional requirement for the legitimacy of any public institution.

A Legislative Record Across Four Domains

The range of legislation Tago authored during his Bangsamoro parliamentary career is broad. It spans education, public health, regional governance structures, labor standards, and historical commemoration. The common thread across these fields is the conviction that post-conflict institution-building requires simultaneous investment on multiple fronts, and that a legislature waiting for stability before it legislates will wait indefinitely.

Education and Health

The Bangsamoro Science High School System Act, which Tago principally authored,<ref name="bionote"/> addresses a structural gap in the region's educational pipeline. The BARMM has historically produced students who leave for specialist schools in Metro Manila or the Visayas and, in many cases, do not return. A regional science high school system creates specialized academic pathways within the region itself, producing the scientists and engineers a developing economy needs without requiring students to uproot themselves from their communities.

The Medical Scholarship and Return Service Program of the Ministry of Health,<ref name="parliament_profile">Bangsamoro Parliament, "TAGO, PAISALIN P.," Member of Parliament Profile, accessed March 10, 2026, https://parliament.bangsamoro.gov.ph/member-parliament/atty-tago-paisalin-p/</ref> another principal-authored measure, attacks a related problem: the chronic shortage of physicians in the BARMM's most isolated provinces. The program funds medical education for Bangsamoro students in exchange for a service commitment in regional hospitals, a straightforward mechanism for addressing the geographic maldistribution of health professionals that has long meant residents of Tawi-Tawi or Sulu face a different quality of medical care than residents of Cotabato City.

Governance Architecture

Two of Tago's most structurally significant legislative contributions are the Bangsamoro Electoral Code and the Bangsamoro Local Governance Code.<ref name="bionote"/> The Local Governance Code, which went through public consultations before passage,<ref name="lgc_consult">Bangsamoro Parliament, "Bangsamoro Parliament starts public consultation on Local Governance Code," February 9, 2022, accessed March 10, 2026, https://parliament.bangsamoro.gov.ph/2022/02/09/bangsamoro-parliament-starts-public-consultation-on-local-governance-code/</ref> established the formal framework governing the relationship between the BARMM and its constituent local government units. The code framed that relationship as a partnership, placing obligations on both the regional government and the LGUs, departing from the more strictly hierarchical models that had characterized previous autonomous region arrangements. Tago also advocated for the establishment of an Administrative Capital in Parang, Maguindanao,<ref name="parliament_profile"/> a decentralization initiative aimed at distributing the practical functions of regional governance more evenly across BARMM territory.

Historical Commemoration

Among the less administratively prominent but symbolically significant measures Tago authored is the resolution declaring May 2 as Battle of Bayang Day,<ref name="parliament_profile"/> commemorating the Maranao resistance to American colonial military forces at Lake Lanao in the early twentieth century. He also pushed for the designation of the burial sites of Sheikh Salamat Hashim, founder of the Moro Islamic Liberation Front, as protected memorial sites.<ref name="parliament_profile"/> These commemorative measures proceed from a clear reading of the peace process: durable reconciliation requires official acknowledgment of historical injury, and a state unwilling to recognize the sacrifices of Bangsamoro leaders and communities will struggle to persuade their descendants that it is genuinely interested in their welfare.

Ministry of Transportation and Communications

Tago was appointed Minister of Transportation and Communications in the Bangsamoro Government in September 2022, while continuing to serve as Deputy Speaker of the Parliament.<ref name="profile"/> The portfolio placed him in charge of the physical connectivity of one of the Philippines' most geographically fragmented regions, a territory that stretches across island chains and mountainous terrain, much of it still rebuilding from the disruption

caused by the 2017 Marawi Siege. In this context, infrastructure development is not separable from governance. The presence or absence of reliable roads, functioning ports, and accessible transportation offices is one of the primary ways that citizens in remote communities experience, or fail to experience, the regional government as real.

Access, Connectivity, and Enforcement

During his tenure, the MOTC conducted assessments of regional airport facilities, including an inspection of Wao Airport in Lanao del Sur,<ref name="motc_tag">MOTC-BARMM, "minister atty paisalin p. tago," Ministry of Transportation Communications, accessed March 10, 2026, https://motc.bangsamoro.gov.ph/tag/minister-atty-paisalin-p-tago/</ref> with a view toward rehabilitation and expanded regional air access. New Bangsamoro Land Transportation Office extension offices were established in areas that had previously required residents to travel to provincial capitals for vehicle registration and licensing services.<ref name="motc_tag"/> These are not dramatic interventions, but they are precisely the kind that build or erode public confidence in regional institutions over time.

Tago also directed anti-colorum enforcement operations within the MOTC's mandate and hosted regional forums on transportation safety and regulatory compliance.<ref name="motc_tag"/> He facilitated the transfer of vessels to the Coast Guard of Basilan Province,<ref name="motc_cpa">MOTC-BARMM, "atty. paisalin p. tago cpa," Ministry of Transportation Communications, accessed March 10, 2026, https://motc.bangsamoro.gov.ph/tag/atty-paisalin-p-tago-cpa/</ref> supporting maritime security in the Sulu Sea. In a region where maritime boundaries are contested and sea lanes are both economically and strategically significant, the integration of transportation policy with security operations is a practical necessity, and one his combined legal and financial background suited him well to manage.

The Ninth President of MSU

Appointment and Oath

The death of MSU System President Atty. Basari D. Mapupuno in May 2025 left a vacancy at one of the Philippines' most symbolically sensitive educational institutions at a critical moment in the Bangsamoro peace process. The selection of his successor was, by definition, a statement of national priorities.

On June 27, 2025, President Ferdinand R. Marcos Jr. signed the appointment of Atty. Paisalin Pangandaman Tago as the 9th Regular President of the MSU System for a six-year term.<ref name="appointment"/> The appointment was transmitted to Commission on Higher Education Chairperson Shirley C. Agrupis in the form prescribed for state university appointments.<ref name="rappler">Rappler, "BARMM lawmaker takes helm of Mindanao State University system," July 3, 2025, accessed March 10, 2026, https://www.rappler.com/philippines/mindanao/barmm-paisalin-tago-state-university-president-marawi-city/</ref> Tago took his oath of office before CHED Chairperson Agrupis on July 1 and again before Executive Secretary Lucas Bersamin at Malacañang on July 2, a sequence that placed his assumption of the MSU presidency formally within both the CHED's academic oversight structure and the Office of the President's administrative authority.

The Investiture

The formal investiture took place on August 13, 2025, at the Dimaporo Gymnasium on the MSU Marawi campus.<ref name="investiture">MSU Buug, "Atty. Paisalin P.D. Tago, CPA, Invested as 9th Regular MSU System President," accessed March 10, 2026, https://msubuug.edu.ph/atty-paisalin-p-d-tago-cpa-invested-as-9th-regular-

msu-system-president/</ref> Among those in attendance were OPAPRU Secretary Carlito G. Galvez Jr., BARMM Interim Chief Minister Abdulraof A. Macacua, and former Senator Aquilino "Koko" Pimentel III.<ref name="appliedhe">AppliedHE, "Atty. Paisalin P.D. Tago Invested as 9th MSU President with Nine-Point Agenda for National Peace University," August 23, 2025, accessed March 10, 2026, https://news.appliedhe.com/2025/08/23/atty-paisalin-p-d-tago-invested-as-9th-msu-president-with-nine-point-agenda-for-national-peace-university/</ref> The roster was notable: the government's primary peace process architect, the Bangsamoro region's highest executive official, and a senator associated with the legal framework of autonomy itself. The composition of the audience was, in a sense, a diagram of the institutional landscape Tago was entering.

> Acta non verba. Actions, not words.|author=Atty. Paisalin P.D. Tago, CPA|source=Inaugural Address, Investiture Ceremony, August 13, 2025

In his inaugural address, Tago grounded his administration in the Latin maxim *Acta non verba* and presented a Nine-Point Agenda alongside a declaration of MSU's aspiration to be formally recognized as the country's National Peace University.<ref name="appliedhe"/> The phrase was not rhetorical flourish. Throughout his career, Tago has operated with a consistent preference for the measurable over the declaratory, for structures and mechanisms and institutions that actually work rather than policies that are merely announced.

The Nine-Point Agenda

The Nine-Point Agenda Tago introduced at his investiture is organized around a single governing logic: that MSU's capacity to serve as an instrument of peace and development depends on it first becoming a well-governed, internationally credible, and community-accountable institution. Excellence and peace, in this framing, are not competing priorities. Institutional excellence is the precondition for everything else.<ref name="newsletter_sep">MSU Main Campus, "University Newsletter September 2025 Issue," accessed March 10, 2026, https://www.msumain.edu.ph/wp-content/uploads/2025/09/09-2025-September-MSU-Newsletter.pdf</ref>

Governance and Strategic Planning (Points 1 and 2)

Point 1 addresses Institutional Alignment, the standardization of policies, ethical frameworks, and accountability mechanisms across MSU's eight constituent universities and three constituent colleges.<ref name="newsletter_sep"/> The MSU System's geographic spread, from Marawi to Sulu to Palawan, has historically produced significant administrative variation between campuses. Aligning those campuses under a common governance framework is not about uniformity for its own sake; it is about ensuring that a student or faculty member at MSU-Sulu receives the same quality of institutional support as one at the main campus in Marawi.

Point 2 commits the system to strategic planning that aligns campus development with BARMM priorities and international educational benchmarks.<ref name="newsletter_sep"/> Campus-level plans must be legible in two directions at once: downward toward the regional government's development agenda and upward toward global standards of academic quality.

Quality, Curriculum, and Cultural Heritage (Points 3, 4, and 5)

Point 3 targets quality assurance through the pursuit of ASEAN University Network Quality Assurance (AUN-QA) certification and ISO accreditation, combined with faculty mobility programs that would expose MSU's teaching staff to academic institutions in other countries.<ref name="newsletter_sep"/> The pursuit of international accreditation serves a double purpose: it subjects MSU's academic programs to external peer review, and it makes MSU's degrees legible to employers and graduate programs outside the Philippines.

Point 4, curriculum enhancement, includes two additions worth noting separately. The institutionalization of Peace Education as a core academic offering transforms a rhetorical commitment, MSU as a peace university, into a curricular reality.<ref name="newsletter_sep"/> The introduction of a "Halal 101" course acknowledges the growing commercial and regulatory significance of the halal industry across Southeast Asia and positions MSU graduates to participate in that economy.

Point 5 commits to the rehabilitation of the King Faisal Mosque on the MSU Marawi campus and the restoration of the Aga Khan Museum, both of which sustained damage during the 2017 siege.<ref name="newsletter_sep"/> These are not decorative features. The King Faisal Mosque is an active house of worship for the MSU community and a gift from the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia. The Aga Khan Museum is one of the few institutional repositories of Maranao cultural heritage in the country. Their rehabilitation is a matter of institutional dignity, and a signal to the Maranao community that the university takes its cultural custodianship seriously.

Human Resources, Student Welfare, and Digitalization (Points 6, 7, and 8)

Point 6 establishes a merit-based framework for faculty development and promotion, paired with an explicit institutional emphasis on integrity as a performance standard.<ref name="newsletter_sep"/> In a state university where political considerations have historically intersected with personnel decisions, articulating merit as the operative criterion is a governance commitment with real institutional stakes.

Point 7 prioritizes student welfare, with specific attention to mental health services and support for "vulnerable learners," a category that in the MSU context includes a significant proportion of students who entered the university as internally displaced persons, conflict-affected youth, or first-generation college students from isolated communities.<ref name="newsletter_sep"/> The explicit inclusion of mental health in a university president's agenda is still relatively uncommon in Philippine higher education, and its presence here reflects an accurate reading of what the MSU student population has actually been through.

Point 8 addresses digital transformation through laboratory modernization, smart campus infrastructure, and environmentally sustainable campus operations.<ref name="newsletter_sep"/> The "green campus" element responds to the environmental pressures on Lake Lanao, the water body around which MSU Marawi is built and on which much of the region's agricultural and fishing economy depends.

Public Engagement and Campus Security (Point 9)

The ninth point covers public engagement and campus security, an acknowledgment that a university in post-conflict Mindanao has constituencies and responsibilities that extend well beyond its enrolled student population.<ref name="newsletter_sep"/> The commitment to transparency in institutional communications responds to a long-standing criticism of Philippine state universities: that their internal governance processes are opaque to the communities they are supposed to serve. The security component reflects the practical reality of operating a major campus in a region where the normalization of peace, though real and advancing, is not yet complete.

First Hundred Days and the Philosophy of the Inclusive University

On October 13, 2025, President Tago presented a performance report to the MSU community covering his first hundred days in office.<ref name="profile"/> The report documented early institutional movement: scholarship protocols with the Turkish Higher Education Council (YÖK) had been renewed and extended; strategic planning processes had been activated across constituent campuses; preparatory work on the heritage restoration initiatives had begun. It was, in part, a demonstration of method, proof that his inaugural pledge of actions over words was being taken seriously as an operating principle.

The philosophical center of his administration found expression during MSU's 64th Founding Anniversary on September 1, 2025, celebrated under the theme *Inklusibong Pamantasan* (Inclusive University).<ref name="newsletter_dec">MSU Main Campus, "December 2025 Newsletter Issue," accessed March 10, 2026, https://www.msumain.edu.ph/wp-content/uploads/2025/12/December-2025-Newsletter-Issue.pdf</ref> His public address introduced the phrase "Volt In" as a rallying call:

> Dapat magsama-sama tayo. (We must come together.)|author=Atty. Paisalin P.D. Tago, CPA|source=MSU 64th Founding Anniversary Address, September 1, 2025

The simplicity was deliberate. Tago has described MSU's primary institutional obligation as actively building an environment where communities separated by conflict, geography, and political marginalization can work together within a shared institution.<ref name="newsletter_dec"/>

The Maranao Tradition and Institutional Leadership

In the Maranao community, traditional leaders, the datus and sultans, are understood as moral arbiters whose authority derives from their capacity to clarify competing interests and broker agreements that communities will actually honor.<ref name="researchgate">ResearchGate, "The Role of Maranao Traditional Leaders and Local Political Leaders towards Collaboration in Promotion of Peace in Marawi City," accessed March 10, 2026, https://www.researchgate.net/publication/279226930</ref> This form of leadership is not about command; it is about legitimacy continuously earned through demonstrated judgment and fidelity to the community's welfare. Tago's repeated emphasis on collaborative governance, on LGUs as partners, on traditional leaders as necessary interlocutors in conflict resolution, and on the university as a place where diverse communities negotiate shared space, is consistent with this tradition, even when it is framed in the language of contemporary public administration.

He has described MSU's role as that of a "culturally inclusive custodian," an institution where the Maranao tradition of mediated community life is not an artifact to be preserved under glass but a living resource to be applied to the challenges of a post-conflict society.<ref name="newsletter_dec"/> Under this reading, MSU's cultural specificity is not in tension with its national mandate. It is the quality that makes MSU uniquely suited to fulfill it.

International Academic Partnerships

President Tago has moved to expand MSU's international academic profile. The University of Muhammadiyah Yogyakarta's Faculty of Law signed a Memorandum of Agreement with MSU under his administration, establishing a collaboration focused on Islamic law and regional peacebuilding in Southeast Asia.<ref name="umy">Universitas Muhammadiyah Yogyakarta, "FH UMY and Mindanao State University Sign MoA, Strengthening Collaboration in Islamic Law and Peace Studies in Southeast Asia," accessed March 10, 2026, https://www.umy.ac.id/en/fh-umy-dan-mindanao-state-university-teken-moa-perkuat-kolaborasi-hukum-islam-dan-perdamaian-asia-tenggara/</ref> Muhammadiyah is among the largest Islamic civil society organizations in the world, and its university network has extensive experience in Islamic jurisprudence education. For MSU, whose long-term aspiration is formal recognition as a National Peace University, the association with an Indonesian institution of that standing in Islamic law is both academically useful and reputationally significant within the OIC academic community.

Legacy and Significance

The career of Atty. Paisalin P.D. Tago is, at its core, a study in the relationship between institutional knowledge and institutional change. He did not arrive at the MSU presidency as an outsider with a reform mandate. He arrived as someone who had spent thirty years inside the institutions that govern Muslim Mindanao, someone who had seen, from the accounting offices and the legislative chamber and the executive suite, what those institutions could do and where they broke down.

The fiscal architecture he helped build in the BARMM, the block grant, the Revenue Code, the digital administration framework, is already producing measurable results. PHP 337 billion in transfers to the Bangsamoro Government over four years<ref name="dof"/> is not an abstraction; it is the material basis on which regional health programs, infrastructure projects, and educational initiatives have been funded and sustained. The legislative measures he authored on education and health are creating the human capital pipelines that isolated Bangsamoro communities have needed for decades.

At MSU, the Nine-Point Agenda translates the same governing logic into an academic setting: identify the structural problems, build the mechanisms to address them, measure the results, and adjust. The ambition to position MSU as a National Peace University is not separable from the commitment to make it a well-governed, accredited, financially accountable, and community-engaged institution first. Tago knows from experience that aspirations without operational foundations do not survive the test of time.

> Acta non verba. The phrase has served as a standard of legal conduct for centuries. In Marawi City, in 2025, it has acquired a new institutional address.|author=Ashary S. Tamano, CESO IV|source=Bangsamoro Digital Ecosystem Journal Series.

Recognition and Awards

Atty. Tago's professional contributions have been recognized across multiple government levels. His fellowship at the East-West Center placed him among a select cohort of emerging Asian and Pacific leaders identified for demonstrated public service potential.<ref name="bionote"/> His appointment as the 9th Regular President of the MSU System by President Ferdinand R. Marcos Jr. represents the highest formal recognition of his career, placing him at the helm of the Philippines' foremost peace university at a pivotal moment in the Bangsamoro peace process.<ref name="appointment"/>

See Also

- Mindanao State University
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Bangsamoro Organic Law
- Bangsamoro Parliament
- Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Marawi City
- Maranao people
- Bangsamoro peace process
- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
- Office on Muslim Affairs (Philippines)

Further Reading

- MSU Main Campus. "Atty. Paisalin P. Tago, CPA: A New Era of Leadership for MSU Towards Peace, Development, and Quality Education in Mindanao." Accessed March 10, 2026. https://www.msumain.edu.ph/atty-paisalin-p-tago-cpa-a-new-era-of-leadership-for-msu-towards-peace-development-and-quality-education-in-mindanao/
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